

COOK WITH BREE

From Buziga with Love

Kitchen stories & recipes from Uganda and beyond

A printable ebook from the Cook with Bree kitchen

Welcome

This little book is a love letter to the kitchen I grew up in — and to the one I cook in now. Inside you'll find stories from Buziga, Kampala: my parents' open affection, my sister Salma, Friday folk tales, chapati and rolex — alongside recipes you can make at home.

Cook slowly. Taste often. Share generously.

With love,

Bree

PART ONE

Stories from the Kitchen

STORY

Growing Up in Uganda

Buziga, my sister Salma, Friday folk tales from my dad, and the matooke and luwombo that still taste like home.

People sometimes ask where my love of food really started. The honest answer is Uganda.

I grew up in Buziga — a wealthy neighbourhood in Kampala with green compound walls, bougainvillea spilling over gates, and the hum of generators on warm evenings when the power dipped. From the outside it looked like comfort. From the inside, it felt like a world that moved at its own pace: neighbours who knew each other's names, Sunday lunches that stretched into the late afternoon, and a kitchen that was always the centre of the house.

I have one younger sister, Salma. She and I could not have been more different.

I was the one hovering near the stove, asking questions, tasting too early, getting in the way because I couldn't stand not knowing what came next. Salma was the one who appeared when the good smells had already done their work — sliding into the kitchen just as something was ready, with that look that said I was busy, but I'm here now. We fought about everything. We shared everything too.

Our cook — and in a house like ours, there was always someone wonderful in the kitchen — had the patience of a saint. She'd shoo me away with one hand and pull me back with the other. "Come," she'd say, "tell me if this needs salt." Salma would wander in later, steal a piece of fruit from the counter, and sit on the stool watching us both like a tiny critic.

My favourite dishes from those years are still my favourites now. Matooke with groundnut sauce — soft, steamed green bananas with that rich, nutty peanut stew that fills the whole house with smell before it ever reaches the table. And roasted beef luwombo, wrapped and slow-cooked until the meat falls apart and every bite carries smoke and patience and time. I didn't know then that I was learning what good food meant. I just knew I wanted more.

Those meals weren't fancy in the way people sometimes imagine when they hear the word wealthy. They were abundant. Rice and stew on weekdays. Chapati torn straight from the pan before it had properly cooled. Platters at gatherings where everyone ate with their hands and no one apologised for taking seconds. The food was never just food. It was proof that the day had gone well, that someone had cared enough to feed you properly, that you belonged at the table.

But the table wasn't the only place where stories lived in our house.

My dad was an engineer by day and a storyteller by night. Every Friday — because there was no school over the weekend and the evening felt wide open — he'd gather us in the sitting room and tell folk tales, or stories from his own past, his voice dropping low for the scary parts and rising for the funny ones. Salma and I would sit cross-legged on the floor, fighting sleep, not wanting to miss the ending. Those nights taught me something cooking would later confirm: the best things in life take time, and the ones worth remembering are almost always shared.

I think about Uganda every time I cook now — not as a postcard, but as a feeling. The warmth of a kitchen. Salma laughing from the next room. My father's voice on a Friday evening. The steam rising off a bowl of matooke. The understanding that a good meal is never really about what's on the plate. It's about who you're feeding, and who feeds you back.

This blog is full of recipes I've learned since leaving home. But the foundation was laid long before that — in a house in Buziga, with my sister Salma, a father who could build bridges and tell stories, and more love than I knew what to do with.

Some stories you carry in your hands. Some you carry in your mouth. This one is both.

STORY

My Parents' Love

We grew up thinking Valentine's Day was a public holiday. In Uganda, public affection was frowned upon — but my parents didn't care.

My parents loved each other so much that, for a long time, Salma and I thought Valentine's Day was a public holiday.

I mean that almost literally. February 14th arrived in our house in Buziga the way Christmas arrived — with anticipation, with fuss, with the sense that the day itself belonged to something bigger than a Tuesday. There were flowers. There were cards. There was a special meal that smelled like celebration before it even reached the table. Our parents dressed up a little. They smiled at each other in that private way that made Salma and me roll our eyes and secretly feel safer than we knew how to say.

In Uganda, that kind of open affection was not the norm.

Public displays of affection — holding hands, kissing, lingering too long in a goodbye — were frowned upon. Love was supposed to be quiet, private, respectable. You didn't put it on display. You didn't make a holiday of it. You kept it behind compound walls and closed doors, if you showed it at all.

My parents didn't care.

They held hands in the driveway. They laughed too loudly at each other's jokes. My father would steal a kiss when he thought no one was looking — and we were always looking. My mother would lean into his side while he told Friday stories, as if the folk tales weren't complete without her shoulder against his. On Valentine's Day they made the whole house part of the celebration, and if the neighbours noticed, so be it.

Salma and I used to tease them for it. We also soaked it in. We didn't have the words then for what we were learning — that love can be loud, that tenderness isn't weakness, that a marriage can be warm enough to make two children believe a commercial holiday was written into the national calendar.

I think about them whenever I cook for someone I love. Not because every meal needs flowers and a card, but because the best kitchens I know are the ones where affection is allowed to show — in the way someone tastes the stew for you, or waits for you to finish rolling the chapati, or sets an extra place without being asked.

My parents taught us that love doesn't have to whisper to be proper.

Sometimes it gets the whole day off.

STORY

My Sister Salma

Salma stirred up trouble and I somehow took the blame — we used to joke one of us was adopted. We both loved the kitchen anyway, just in completely different ways.

My sister Salma and I did not always get along.

We were — and still are — completely different people. I don't mean different in the polite way adults say when they're trying to make peace at a family dinner. I mean genuinely, bafflingly, almost-comically different. The kind of different that makes you stare at each other across the breakfast table and wonder how two people raised in the same house, by the same parents, in the same neighbourhood in Buziga, could turn out so little alike.

We used to joke about it. One of us, we decided, had to be adopted.

It was never serious — or at least, we never said it seriously. But the joke had teeth. Salma was the messy one — always stirring up trouble, leaving a trail of chaos behind her, and somehow managing to make it look like my fault by the time our parents walked in. I was the one trying to explain what had actually happened while she stood there looking innocent. We argued about everything: whose turn it was, who broke what, who started it, who finished it. Standard sister warfare, except ours always had this extra layer of how are we even related.

What we did have in common — the thing that always brought us back together — was the kitchen.

We both loved it. Not in the same way, but with the same seriousness. I was the creative one — always experimenting, adding something that wasn't in the recipe, asking what if we tried this? Salma was the precise one. An amazing cook in her own right — patient, careful, the kind of person who could follow a recipe once and nail it every time after. Where I wanted to invent, she wanted to perfect. I'd hover and taste too early. She'd wait until the moment was right and produce something flawless.

I used to think that meant we were competing. I was wrong. We were just two people who loved the same room for different reasons.

What I didn't understand then — what took me years to understand — is that difference isn't distance. It's just difference.

We had the same house, the same parents, the same Friday evenings when our father told stories until we forgot to be annoyed with each other. We had chapati stolen off the pan before it cooled — usually by Salma, usually blamed on me. We had the adopted joke, which only works if you love someone enough to tease them about it.

We're still different. We still are. I don't think that changes. What changed is that I stopped treating it like a problem to solve and started treating it like a fact to enjoy — two versions of the same family, side by side in the same kitchen, occasionally baffled, always connected.

Salma will probably roll her eyes if she reads this. That's how I know it's true.

This blog is full of recipes and stories from my kitchen. But some of the best stories aren't about food at all — they're about the people who taught you that love doesn't always look like agreement. Sometimes it looks like sharing a house with someone who is nothing like you, and choosing to stay anyway.

STORY

Chapati and Rolex

Soft flatbread from our Buziga kitchen, and the rolled-egg street snack — onion and tomato omelette wrapped in chapati — that taught me Uganda's best food doesn't always need a table.

If you grew up in Uganda, chapati is not a special occasion bread. It is Tuesday. It is Sunday lunch stretching into the afternoon. It is the smell of oil and flour hitting a hot pan while someone in the next room asks whether you've done your homework yet.

In our kitchen in Buziga, chapati was the bread we reached for most. Our cook would work through a mound of dough with the kind of calm that only comes from having made the same thing a thousand times — flour and salt, oil rubbed in until the mixture turned crumbly, warm water added slowly, then kneading until the dough felt soft and alive under your hands. She'd cover it with a damp cloth and let it rest while the rest of the meal came together.

Then the rolling. Fourteen balls, each pressed into a thin circle about the size of a dinner plate. Sometimes she'd brush one with oil, fold it, fold it again, and roll it out once more — that extra step for flakiness that makes a chapati pull apart in layers instead of lying flat like a pancake. I've written out the full recipe here on the blog because I didn't want that technique to live only in muscle memory. But the truth is, you learn chapati by watching: how thin is thin enough, how hot the pan should be, when to press gently with a spatula so the bread puffs.

The rule in our house was simple. The first chapati off the pan never made it to the table. Someone — usually me, hovering too close to the stove — would tear off a piece while it was still too hot to hold properly. Salma would appear from wherever she'd been pretending not to care, and we'd burn our fingers together and call it worth it.

At home, chapati went with everything. Stew on a weekday. Beans. Matooke with groundnut sauce. Roasted beef luwombo, torn and wrapped and eaten with your hands like the food gods intended.

But chapati also left the kitchen.

Walk through Kampala on almost any morning and you'll find a rolex — Uganda's favourite street breakfast, and one of the best jokes in East African food. It's not a watch. It's a chapati rolled around an onion and tomato omelette, and the name is a play on rolled eggs said quickly enough to make a vendor smile. Simple. Filling. Exactly right.

The stall version is a small production. A chapati cooked fresh on a flat griddle. Beside it, eggs beaten and poured into the pan — a proper omelette with sliced onions and tomatoes folded through, the edges just set, the centre still soft. Then the chapati is laid flat, the omelette laid down the centre, and the whole thing rolled tight like a burrito and handed to you wrapped in paper, still warm, still slightly greasy in the best possible way.

I loved rolex for what it represented as much as for how it tasted. You didn't need a dining room or a proper table or someone else's schedule. You needed a few hundred shillings, a hungry morning, and a vendor who knew their griddle. Students on their way to school. Office workers grabbing something before the traffic got bad. My sister and I, once we were old enough to be sent on errands, coming home with oil on our fingers and a story

about which corner had the best one that week.

There's a thread between the chapati our cook made at home and the one a street vendor flipped at dawn. Same dough, same principle — flour, patience, heat. One ends up on a platter beside luwombo; the other ends up in your hand on the walk to wherever you're going. Both say the same thing: you are fed, you are cared for, keep moving.

I still make chapati the way I learned in Buziga. I still think about rolex when I need reminding that good food doesn't always require a kitchen full of people and a long afternoon. Sometimes it just needs a hot pan, a rolled egg, and the courage to eat it before it cools.

Some recipes belong in a book. Some belong in your hands, walking down a street you know by heart. Chapati is both.

STORY

Why I Cook

It's not about perfection. It's about showing up — for yourself and for the people around your table.

People ask me sometimes why I cook when there are so many faster options. Delivery apps. Meal kits. Frozen dinners that taste better than they have any right to.

And I get it. I have those nights too — the ones where the idea of chopping an onion feels like climbing a mountain. I'm a product manager. I live in spreadsheets and Slack threads. I know what it means to be tired.

But here's what I've learned: cooking isn't really about the food.

It's about the pause.

When I step into my kitchen after a long day, something shifts. The noise in my head gets quieter. Chopping vegetables is meditative in a way no app can replicate. The sizzle of garlic in olive oil is a reset button I didn't know I needed.

And then there's the sharing part.

There's nothing quite like watching someone's face when they take the first bite of something you made just for them. My friend Sarah still talks about the lemon garlic pasta I made her after a brutal breakup — not because it was the best pasta she'd ever had, but because someone showed up for her with a warm bowl and no questions asked.

That's the magic. Food is a love language, and you don't need to be fluent to speak it.

I cook because it grounds me. Because it connects me to my grandmother, my mother, and every person who's ever fed me with intention. Because on the hardest days, making something nourishing for myself is an act of self-care I can actually follow through on.

This blog isn't about being the best cook in the room. It's about being in the room — present, imperfect, and willing to try.

So pull up a chair. Let's cook something together.

PART TWO

Recipes to Cook

RECIPE

Matooke with Groundnut Sauce

Prep 20 min · Cook 45 min · Serves 6

Steamed green bananas with rich peanut stew — the dish that filled our house in Buziga with smell before it ever reached the table.

Ingredients

Matooke

- 8–10 green cooking bananas (matooke), peeled and wrapped in banana leaves or foil
- 2 cups water, for steaming
- Salt, to taste

Groundnut (Peanut) Sauce

- 1 cup natural peanut butter (or 1 cup roasted peanuts, ground)
- 2 cups water or chicken stock
- 1 small onion, finely chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tbsp tomato paste
- 1/2 tsp smoked paprika (optional)
- 1/2 tsp cumin
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil

Instructions

1. Steam the matooke: Wrap peeled bananas in banana leaves (traditional) or foil bundles. Place in a steamer or large pot with a tight lid and 2 cups water at the bottom. Steam over medium heat for 45–60 minutes until soft and tender.
2. Make the groundnut sauce: Heat oil in a saucepan over medium heat. Sauté onion and garlic until softened, about 5 minutes.
3. Stir in tomato paste and cook for 1 minute. Whisk in peanut butter and water (or stock) until smooth.
4. Add paprika, cumin, salt, and pepper. Simmer on low for 15–20 minutes, stirring often, until the sauce thickens to a pourable stew consistency. Adjust salt to taste.
5. Serve: Mash or slice the steamed matooke and ladle the warm groundnut sauce over the top. Best eaten with your hands or alongside rice.

Bree's Notes

This was my favourite dish growing up in Buziga. The secret is patience — let the matooke steam until it's truly soft, and don't rush the sauce. It should be rich, nutty, and thick enough to cling to every bite.

RECIPE

Chapati

Prep 20 min · Cook 25 min · Serves 14

Soft, flaky East African flatbread — torn straight from the pan before it cools, just like we did growing up in Buziga.

Ingredients

- 10 cups all-purpose flour, plus extra for dusting
- 1 tbsp salt
- 1 cup vegetable oil, plus more for cooking
- 3 cups warm water, plus more as needed

Instructions

1. Make the dough: In a large bowl, whisk together flour and salt. Add 1 cup oil and rub it into the flour with your fingertips until crumbly.
2. Add warm water and knead until a soft, non-sticky dough forms.
3. Cover the dough with a damp cloth and rest for 30 minutes.
4. Shape the chapatis: Divide the dough into 14 equal balls. Roll each ball into a thin circle about 8 inches wide.
5. (Optional) For extra flakiness (the way we made them at home): brush the rolled circle lightly with oil, fold in half, brush again, fold into a quarter, then roll out once more into a thin round.
6. Cook: Heat a dry skillet or chapati pan over medium-high heat. Cook each chapati for 1–2 minutes per side, pressing gently with a spatula so it puffs. Brush lightly with oil as it cooks if you like a richer finish.
7. Serve: Stack cooked chapatis in foil to keep them soft. Serve warm with stew, beans, matooke, or luwombo.

Bree's Notes

Chapati was the bread we reached for most — at weekday dinners and big Sunday gatherings. The rule in our kitchen was simple: the first one off the pan never made it to the table. Someone always tore off a piece while it was still too hot to hold. Roll them thin, cook them hot, and don't wait.

RECIPE

Roasted Beef Luwombo

Prep 30 min · Cook 2 hours · Serves 6

Slow-cooked beef wrapped in banana leaves — smoky, tender, and worth every hour of waiting, just like my dad's Friday stories.

Ingredients

- 2 lbs beef stew meat, cut into chunks
- 2 large onions, sliced
- 4 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 tbsp ginger, minced
- 2 tomatoes, chopped
- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tsp ground coriander
- 1/2 tsp cumin
- 1/2 tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp salt (adjust to taste)
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil
- 1 cup beef stock or water
- 2–3 banana leaves, cleaned and softened over a flame (or parchment paper as substitute)
- Kitchen twine, for tying

Instructions

1. Marinate the beef: In a large bowl, combine beef, half the onions, garlic, ginger, tomato paste, coriander, cumin, pepper, and salt. Mix well and let sit for 30 minutes (or up to 2 hours in the fridge).
2. Prepare banana leaves: Pass banana leaves briefly over an open flame or hot pan until pliable. Cut into large squares for wrapping.
3. Assemble the luwombo: Place a portion of marinated beef and remaining onions/tomatoes in the centre of each leaf square. Add a splash of stock. Fold the leaves tightly into a parcel and secure with kitchen twine.
4. Roast or steam: Place parcels in a heavy pot or roasting pan. Add remaining stock to the bottom. Cover tightly and cook over low heat (or in a 325°F / 163°C oven) for 1.5–2 hours, until the beef is fall-apart tender.
5. Optional roasting finish: For a deeper smoky flavour, unwrap carefully and broil or grill the beef for 5–10 minutes before serving.
6. Serve: Open the parcels at the table. Serve with matooke, rice, or chapati, spooning the collected juices over the meat.

Bree's Notes

Luwombo is patience in a parcel — the banana leaves keep everything moist and infuse a subtle earthy flavour. My dad would tell stories for hours on Friday nights; this dish asks for the same unhurried spirit. Don't peek too early. Let it cook until the meat gives way at the touch of a fork.

RECIPE

English Peas Stew

Prep 15 min · Cook 40 min · Serves 6

Soft English peas simmered in a rich tomato and onion gravy — simple, comforting, and perfect piled next to rice or chapati.

Ingredients

- 3 cups frozen English peas (or fresh shelled peas)
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil
- 1 large onion, finely chopped
- 3 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 tomatoes, chopped (or 1 cup canned crushed tomatoes)
- 1 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 carrot, diced (optional)
- 1 tsp curry powder
- 1/2 tsp ground cumin
- 1/2 tsp paprika
- 2 cups water or vegetable stock
- Salt and black pepper, to taste
- Fresh cilantro or parsley, for serving

Instructions

1. Sauté the base: Heat oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add onion and cook until soft and golden, about 8–10 minutes.
2. Stir in garlic and cook for 1 minute until fragrant. Add tomato paste and cook for another minute.
3. Add chopped tomatoes, curry powder, cumin, and paprika. Cook until the tomatoes break down into a thick sauce, about 5–7 minutes.
4. Add the peas: Stir in English peas and carrot (if using). Pour in water or stock and season with salt and pepper.
5. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat and simmer uncovered for 20–25 minutes, until the peas are tender and the stew has thickened into a rich gravy.
6. Taste and finish: Adjust salt and pepper. If you like a thicker stew, mash a few peas against the side of the pot and stir them back in.
7. Serve: Ladle over rice, next to matooke, or with warm chapati. Top with fresh herbs.

Bree's Notes

English peas stew was a weeknight staple in our house — nothing fancy, just peas, tomatoes, and onion doing quiet work on the stove. Fresh peas are lovely when you can find them, but frozen peas work beautifully and save you the shelling. Don't rush the onion — that golden base is what makes the gravy taste like home.

RECIPE

Coconut Rice (Rice Cooker)

Prep 10 min · Cook 30 min · Serves 6

Fragrant, creamy coconut rice made entirely in the rice cooker — soft, slightly sweet, and ready to go with stew, grilled fish, or a simple weeknight meal.

Ingredients

- 2 cups jasmine or long-grain white rice
- 1 cup full-fat coconut milk (well shaken)
- 1 1/2 cups water
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar (optional, for a hint of sweetness)
- 1 tbsp coconut oil or butter (optional, for richer rice)
- 2–3 cardamom pods, lightly crushed (optional)
- Fresh cilantro or toasted coconut flakes, for serving (optional)

Instructions

1. Rinse the rice: Place rice in a fine-mesh strainer and rinse under cold water until the water runs mostly clear. Drain well.
2. Load the rice cooker: Add rinsed rice, coconut milk, water, salt, sugar (if using), and coconut oil or butter (if using) to the rice cooker pot. Add cardamom pods if you want a light spice fragrance. Stir once to combine.
3. Cook: Close the lid and start a normal white-rice cycle. Do not open the lid while it cooks.
4. Rest: When the cooker switches to warm (or finishes), leave the lid closed for 10 minutes so the steam finishes cooking the grains.
5. Fluff and serve: Open the lid, remove cardamom pods if used, and fluff gently with a fork or rice paddle. Serve warm with English peas stew, grilled chicken, fish, or beans.

Bree's Notes

Coconut rice is one of those sides that makes an ordinary stew feel special. Full-fat coconut milk gives the best texture — light coconut milk can turn out watery. If your rice cooker runs a little dry, add 2–3 extra tablespoons of water next time. Leftovers reheat well with a splash of water or coconut milk.

RECIPE

Grandma's Banana Bread

Prep 15 min · Cook 60 min · Serves 10

Moist, warmly spiced banana bread with brown sugar and yogurt — this is the recipe that's been in my family for three generations.

Ingredients

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 teaspoon baking soda
- 1/4 teaspoon salt
- 1/2 teaspoon ground cinnamon
- 1/2 cup unsalted butter, softened to room temperature
- 3/4 cup packed light or dark brown sugar
- 2 large eggs, at room temperature
- 1/3 cup plain or Greek yogurt, at room temperature
- 1 1/2 cups bananas, mashed
- 1 teaspoon pure vanilla extract
- Optional: 3/4 cup chopped pecans and raisins

Instructions

1. Preheat oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease a 9x5 inch loaf pan.
2. In a large bowl, cream softened butter and brown sugar until light and fluffy. Beat in eggs one at a time, then stir in yogurt, mashed bananas, and vanilla.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk together flour, baking soda, salt, and cinnamon.
4. Add dry ingredients to the wet ingredients, stirring just until combined. Fold in pecans and raisins if using. Don't overmix — lumpy batter is good batter here.
5. Pour into prepared pan and bake for 55-65 minutes, until a toothpick inserted in the center comes out clean.
6. Let cool in the pan for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a wire rack. Best served warm with butter, but honestly it's perfect the next day too.

Bree's Notes

My grandma always said the secret was using bananas so ripe they were almost black. She wasn't wrong. If your bananas aren't quite there yet, pop them in a 300°F oven for 15 minutes to speed things up.

Thank you

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